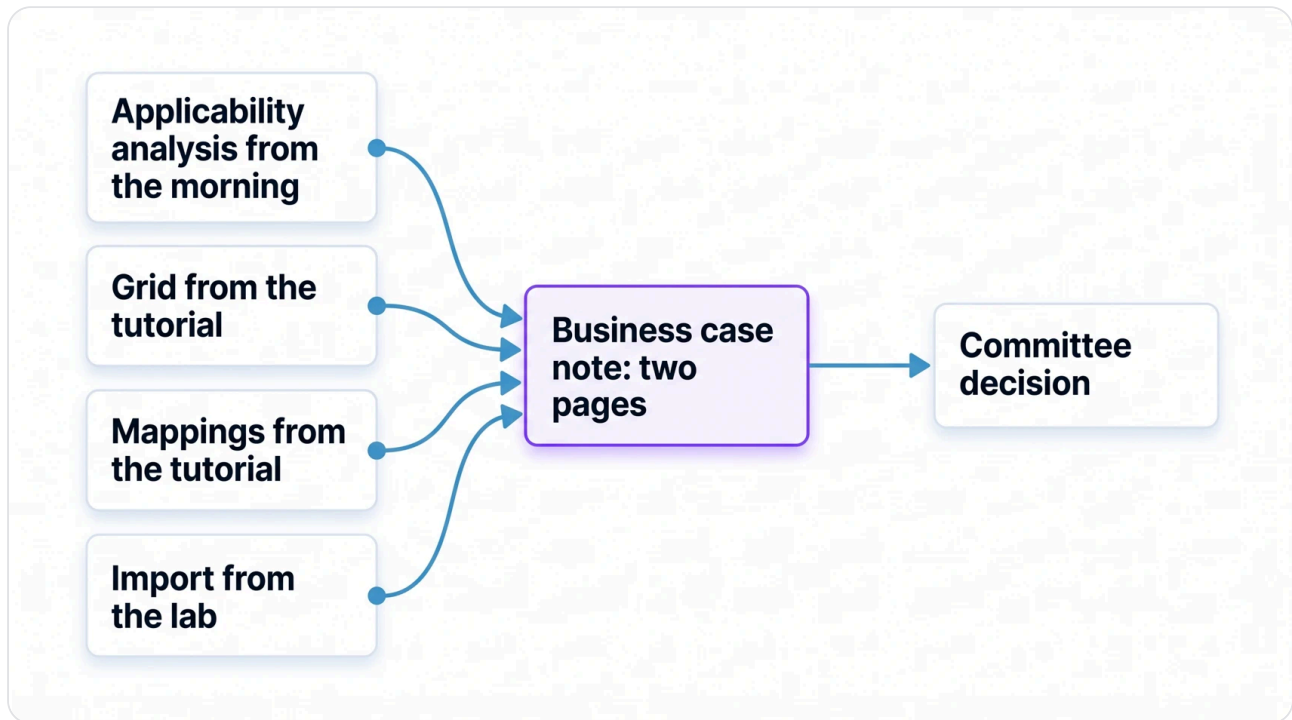


Drafting the business case note and peer review

From conviction to the document that decides



Drafting here means assembling: every claim in the note traces back to a piece of the day's work.

Session objectives

By the end of this lab, the file contains the business case note for the MERIDIAN group's framework choice, reread and improved through a peer review, and the strategy note enriched with its new subsection. What is learned here:

- **Draft** a business case note: a short document that obtains a decision, not a report that avoids one
- **Build** a line of argument for a choice in which every claim is backed by a piece of the day's work
- **Conduct** a peer review with an explicit grid, and receive criticism as data, not as an attack
- **Articulate** the day's decision with the group's strategy note, without rewriting anything that exists

Prerequisites

- The selection grid and the ten-line recommendation from midday's tutorial: the business case note is their finished form.
- The identity sheet and the import completed in the previous lab: the proof that the choice is operational, not theoretical.

- The group's strategy note, begun in session 1 (context and target governance) and enriched in session 2 (critical assets); the third stone is added to it today.

The business case note: obtaining a decision in two pages

First, the notion, because the word is deceptively banal. The problem it solves has already been met twice today: the Chief Executive Officer will read neither the directive, nor the standard, nor the fifteen-cell grid, and yet she is the one who must decide, because a framework commits a budget, teams and the group's word to its clients. Without a document cut for her, the decision gets made in a meeting, on an impression, and gets unmade at the next one. A **business case note** is the short document, two pages at MERIDIAN, that presents to a decision-maker an opportunity to act, the options examined, a reasoned recommendation and the decision requested, worded so that it can be answered yes or no. Its mechanics rest on one discipline: each section answers a question the decision-maker actually asks, in the order in which they ask it. Why now? What have we compared? What does the note recommend and what does it rest on? What does it cost and what does it not cover? What must I decide today? Its limit, finally, which distinguishes it from its cousins: it asks for ONE steering decision, it is neither a scoping note, which organizes work already decided, like the one written in session 1, nor a project plan, which will break down the implementation after the decision. A business case note that ends without a requested decision is an essay lost in the wrong template.

The group's template, the one the deliverable must follow:

SECTION	EXPECTED CONTENT	LENGTH
1. Context and trigger	Why this decision, why now: obligations in force, obligations to come, situation of the subsidiaries	A third of a page
2. Options examined	The tutorial's candidates, each summed up in two honest lines, strengths and limits	Half a third of a page
3. Reasoned recommendation	The choice, the two or three decisive arguments drawn from the grid, the planned reuse via the mappings	Half a page
4. Limits and blind spots	What the choice does not cover, what remains uncertain, what will be monitored	A third of a page
5. Decision requested	One closed sentence, decidable in committee, with the start-up deadline	Three lines

Acceptance criteria for the deliverable, the ones that will be applied as they stand: two pages at most; no numbered claim that does not come from one of the day's sources; the losing options treated with the same regard as the winner, because a note that caricatures the alternatives convinces only its author; section 4 not empty, a note with no declared limits being precisely what makes senior management suspicious; the requested decision answerable by yes or no; and temporal robustness checked: nothing that becomes false if the transposition law is promulgated earlier or later than expected.

Drafting: twenty minutes, two pages, zero improvisation

All the material exists: the context comes from the CISO's briefing and the lecture, the options and the arguments come from the tutorial's grid, the proof of operability comes from the lab, the limits come from the mapping verdicts already delivered. Drafting, here, means assembling and deciding, not inventing.

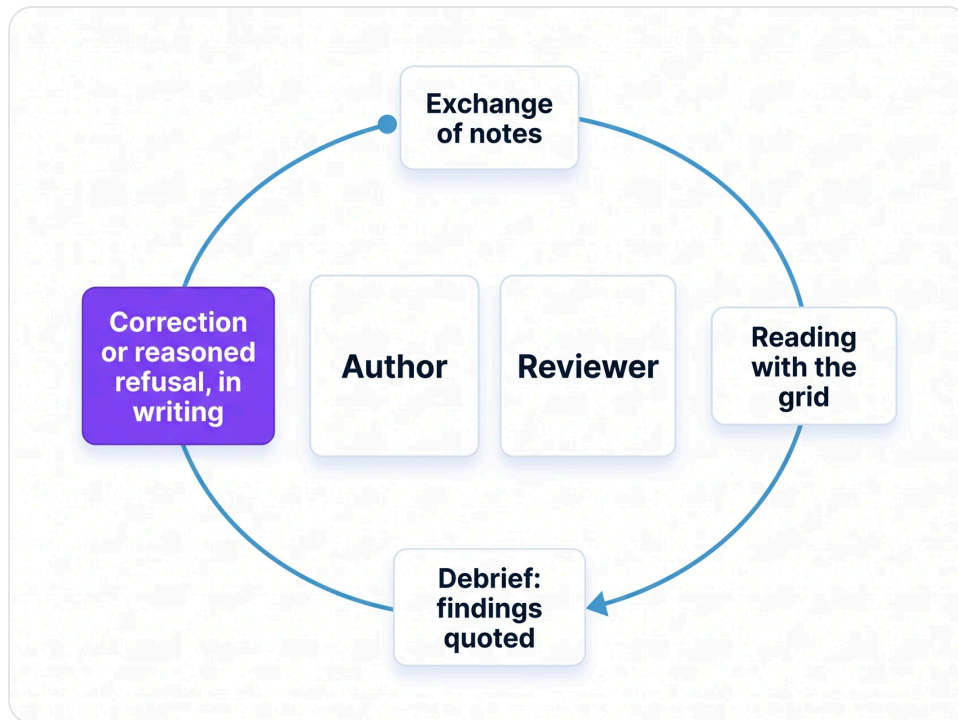
1. **Draft** the complete note, sections 1 to 5, keeping to the template and the acceptance criteria above.

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2. **Trace** each argument of section 3 to its source in the day, with one word in parentheses at the end of the sentence: (grid), (mappings), (import), (applicability). This traceability is not an affectation: it is the first thing the peer review will test.

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3. **Reread** once in a low voice before handing in, asking the only question that matters: without having followed this day, could a reader decide with these two pages?
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The peer review: lending one's eyes, not one's opinion

Second notion of the day, and it will serve well beyond this module. The problem: the author of a document can no longer read it. They know the reasoning, so they see neither the logical leaps nor the implicit prerequisites; every self-rereading confirms what was already believed. A **peer review** is the organized exchange of deliverables between peers, each rereading the other's with an explicit grid and returning a reasoned verdict. The important word is "grid": without it, the review produces judgements of taste, "I would have put it differently", which serve nothing and vex everyone. With it, the review produces verifiable findings: this claim has no source, this decision is not decidable. The mechanics are a contract between peers: the reviewer commits to the grid, nothing but the grid; the author commits to addressing every finding, by correcting or by justifying the refusal in writing, never by ignoring it. The limit, to know so as not to over-invest the exercise: a peer review checks the solidity of the document, not the soundness of the choice; two notes recommending two different frameworks can both come out of a review excellent, and it is the committee that will decide. The reviewer is not a second decision-maker.



The peer review is a contract: the grid bounds the reviewer, and every finding receives a correction or a reasoned refusal.

The protocol (ten minutes)

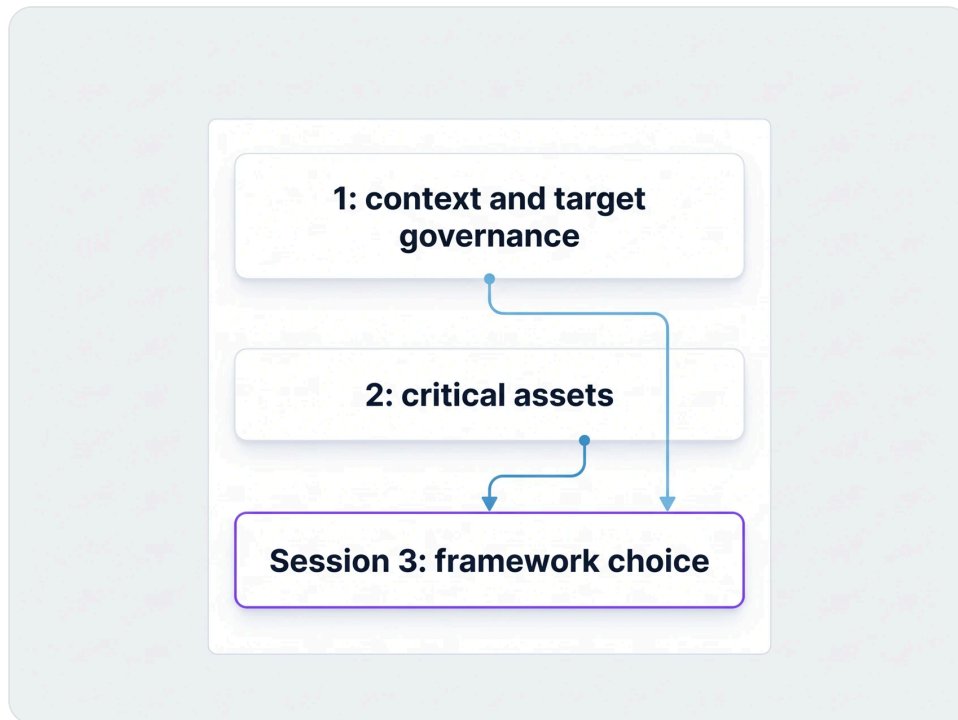
1. **Exchange** the note produced with the partner's, preferably one from another subsidiary: distance from the context makes the eye fresher.
.....
2. **Reread** the note received with the grid below, noting for each line a precise finding, quotation in support, never a general impression.
.....
3. **Report back** in three minutes: the two most useful findings first, the rest after; the author notes everything and does not defend themselves during the report, they will address it afterwards.
.....
4. **Address** the findings received on one's own note: each finding receives a correction or a one-line reasoned refusal, before final submission.
.....

GRID QUESTION	WHAT IS BEING LOOKED FOR
Does every numbered claim have a source from the day?	The traceability parentheses, and their accuracy
Are the losing options treated honestly?	One real strength line for each discarded option
Does the limits section say something substantial?	At least one owned blind spot, not a stock phrase
Is the requested decision decidable?	It can be answered yes or no without asking for further analysis
Does the note survive both calendars?	Nothing becomes false depending on the law's promulgation date

Strategy note (15 minutes)

Last quarter of an hour, the module's ritual: the group's strategy note gains its subsection for the session, the third. A "Framework choice" subsection is added, half a page at most, which rewrites NOTHING of the business case note: the strategy note carries the group's trajectory, not the decision file. What it contains: the framework retained and the date of the decision; in one sentence, why this one, the strategic version of the arguments, not their detail; and what this choice commits for the rest of the trajectory, the compliance assessment created in the tool and the audit on the horizon.

The articulation with the existing text is the real difficulty, and the real marking criterion. The "context and target governance" subsection from session 1 established who decides and through which bodies: the new subsection must refer to it, the framework decision being precisely a product of that governance. The "critical assets" subsection from session 2 established what matters most: the chosen framework is the language in which these assets will from now on be assessed, and one sentence must make that link. The document's constraints, to keep in mind: three pages at most for the whole, nothing gets deleted, everything can be amended with a one-sentence justification, and the exercise counts for 10 points in the module's marking scheme. If the addition pushes beyond three pages, it is a signal of density, not an invitation to cut a previous session: tighten the new subsection.



The third subsection rests on the first two: governance produces the decision, the assets gain their language of assessment.

And to close the session, the sentence that hands it on: the framework chosen and imported today becomes the audit framework of session 4, where the group will measure, requirement by requirement, the gap between what it claims and what it does; the accepted business case note will be the first exhibit in that file.

Answer keys and assessment criteria

Answer key: a business case note that holds, section by section

One possible model, to be read AFTER handing in one's own note, to compare choices rather than copy them. Section 1: two of the group's subsidiaries will enter the scope of the European regulation upon promulgation of the French law, one of them very probably under the most demanding regime; since this week the group has an up-to-date mapping and a governance tool; deciding now costs less than being driven by the calendar. Section 2: three options examined; the hygiene guide, a free and immediate base but with no defensible proof and no group governance; the coming French framework, aligned with the future obligation but still a working version; the international standard, structuring and certifiable but voluntary and demanding in effort. Section 3: recommendation to adopt ISO/IEC 27001:2022 as the backbone (grid), because it is the only option that both governs four disparate subsidiaries under one system AND produces proof enforceable towards clients (grid), the effort being reusable for future compliance via the established mappings (mappings), and the tooling being already in place, framework imported and assessment created this day (import). Section 4: this choice does not amount to regulatory compliance, which will remain to be demonstrated objective by objective; the French framework will evolve until the decrees and will be monitored; the cost of certification is not priced at this stage and will be the subject of a separate note. Section 5: the Executive Committee is asked to approve the adoption of ISO/IEC 27001:2022 as the group's security framework and the launch of the initial assessment, decision expected Thursday.

This model is not the single right answer: a note recommending the French framework as the backbone, with the standard as the second line, passes the same criteria if its section 4 owns the instability of a working document. It is the traced coherence, not the conclusion, that is marked.

Assessment criteria for the deliverable

CRITERION	INSUFFICIENT	EXPECTED	EXCELLENT
Template and format	Missing sections or three pages	Five sections, two pages	Same, and each section answers its opening question
Traceability	Claims without a source	Each argument traced to a piece of the day's work	Same, sources verified as accurate in the peer review
Honesty of the options	Caricatured alternatives	One real strength per discarded option	Same, and the best objection to the recommended choice is stated then addressed
Decision requested	Absent or vague	Closed, decidable, dated	Same, with the first concrete step after the yes
Peer review	Findings ignored	Each finding corrected or refused in writing	Same, and the report given to the partner was quoted and actionable
Strategy note	Subsection copying the business case note	Half a page articulated with the subsections of sessions 1 and 2	Same, within the three-page limit, amendments justified in one sentence